

A full-page photograph of Paralympic athlete Sumit Antil in the middle of a javelin throw. He is wearing a blue singlet with 'Allianz' and 'SUMIT' logos, and black shorts. He has a prosthetic left leg. The javelin is in his right hand, extended forward. The background shows a large stadium filled with spectators and banners for the Paris 2024 Paralympics.

Top-tier performance: Sumit Antil broke the tournament record twice, starting with a massive opening throw of 69.11m, breaking his own previous Paralympic record of 68.55m set in Tokyo. He then went one better with a 70.59m throw on his second attempt. No one else in the field came close to either distance. GETTY IMAGES

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If you were walking past Sumit Antil's room in the Paralympic village the night before his big javelin final, you might have heard songs from the 2013 film *Bhaag Milkha Bhaag*. As sleep evaded him before the big day, some spine-tingling cinematic inspiration was his go-to remedy to run the clock down.

Much of it was pre-final adrenaline, but there was also some nervousness about the discomfort in his back that kept Sumit up.

"From early 2023, I started feeling pain in the L4, L5 region of my back. It's a fairly common problem area for javelin throwers. The pressure I was putting on my front leg to block was adding to the strain on my back. Only rest and strengthening can help in this case, but I wasn't able to give my body that because of back-to-back competitions," Sumit told Sportstar, with a gold medal and a Paralympic record safely in the bag.

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For able-bodied athletes, javelin requires every engaged muscle to be in top shape to execute a throw with perfection. Look at Neeraj Chopra in the Paris Olympics a few weeks ago. His adductor issue visibly stiffened his blocking leg, and the advantage he gained from his run-up speed was hampered, as was the force he could exert on his left leg.

"When you have an injury, you lose the support of those muscles in your throw. That load shifts to another muscle, which disturbs your technique. I felt that pain (in my back) after my third throw last night."

That was a 66.66m throw, his second-lowest of the night. Right